



DO STATES NEED MORE AUTONOMY TO DELIVER CHANGE?

“Decentralisation of power will bring stability”

HEMANT CHAWLA



“Hold Parliament and state polls together”

SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN

CHIEF MINISTER, MADHYA PRADESH

This is the age of coalition governments. The dynamics of all this is in the interplay between the Centre and parties in power in the states, whether they are the same, are opposed to each other or are coalition partners. Coalition partners extract the most they can from the Centre, which finds it politically expedient to give away. Some states get special packages. For example, if the railway minister is from a certain state, railway lines will be con-

structed in that state only. And if a state like Madhya Pradesh asks for funds for the construction of railway lines, we are told that you have to first contribute 50 per cent of the funds for that. This is just one example.

The Central government makes laws for the entire country but the diversity of the culture, the people and the states is overlooked. We then have to apply the law in the same form whether the state is Nagaland or Jammu and Kashmir. Sometimes it is very difficult to implement such laws. Therefore states should be given more autonomy. One more thing I would like to stress upon is election reforms. We seem to have a continuous process of elections taking place in the country. This creates a vicious atmosphere and brings development to a halt. I propose that elections to state assemblies as

CHOUHAN

